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AI leadership
development platform
Praxis Labs sells to Torch



Dominic-Madori Davis — 1:00 PM PDT · July 11, 2025

Praxis Labs, a learning development platform, announced its acquisition on Thursday for an undisclosed amount by the [leadership and coaching enterprise Torch](#)

“As a small company with fewer than 100 people serving companies as large as Amazon, we knew we needed to build powerful partnerships, across product and go-to-market, to reach more companies,” co-founder and CEO of Praxis Labs, Elise Smith, told [TechCrunch](#) about the reason for the sale.

She and her co-founder, Heather Shen, met Torch CEO Heather Conklin as they were both already working in the leadership development space.

“We were immediately struck, not just by our shared values and mission, but also by how we aligned on what was needed to really future-proof the next general workforce,” Smith continued. “There was a clear connection and opportunity to connect Torch’s contextual coaching and organizational insights with Praxis’ AI coaching, practice, and skill assessments.”

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HEATHER CONKLIN, THE CEO OF TORCH

IMAGE CREDITS: HEATHER CONKLIN

Praxis Labs launched in 2019 and worked with companies such as eBay, Zoom, Amazon, Google, and Target to build out more equitable and inclusive workplaces through leadership training and skill assessments. It notably secured a \$15 million Series A back in 2021, making Smith [one of the few Black women at the time](#) to raise more than \$1 million in venture capital funding. Investors in that round included Emerson Collective, Steph Curry's fund Penny Jar Capital, Precursor Ventures, and Ulu Ventures.

Smith and Shen will join Torch as head of AI growth and head of AI product, respectively. The Praxis team will also be joining Torch.

"Right now, every company and executive team is facing this pivotal question: How will they prepare and manage this next generation of work with humans and AI, while maintaining the human connection that's essential for real workforce and company transformation?" she said.

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“We’re confident that joining Torch gives us the best possible opportunity to help companies solve this question in this crucial moment.”

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Senior Reporter, Venture |

Dominic-Madori Davis is a senior venture capital and startup reporter at TechCrunch. She is based in New York...

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Tulsa's tech scene remains resilient amid state's anti-DEI efforts

Dominic-Madori Davis — 9:00 AM PST · January 7, 2024

Oklahoma took a stand against diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) last month. The state's governor, Kevin Stitt, signed [an executive order](#) defunding DEI efforts in public colleges and universities and banning it in other state agencies.

He said the move would take “politics out of education” and encourage “equal opportunity rather than promising equal outcomes.” Affirmative action itself has been banned in the state since 2012.

This [latest executive](#) order does not target student organizations, but it does ban state resources from

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being used for diversity training and asks for a review of current DEI programs to eliminate any

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DEI is at odds with the efforts of its Tulsa tech hub. For the past decade, Tulsa [has been trying to attract talent](#) from all over the nation. It's also, most notably, trying to rebuild Black Wall Street, a once-prosperous Black business neighborhood [that white supremacists bombed](#) in the 1920s.

[Tulsa is trying to build a startup ecosystem from scratch](#)

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Tré Baker, managing director at Tulsa Techstars, said that the executive order does not materially change business on the ground. The city's ecosystem has become accustomed to dealing with constraints since affirmative action was banned in the state back in 2012. The government also has no control over private investment decisions. He said it's as simple as not publicly announcing any preference for one group over another.

"The problem is not the law, the problem has always been people making investment decisions," he said. "When we empower more Black investors, more Black founders will get funded."

Still, others are afraid this could dampen the appeal of Tulsa that attracted people to the city in the first place. Nicholas Lalla, the founder of Tulsa Innovation Labs, said that much of the Tulsa tech scene was built with inclusion in mind and that the executive order is "counterproductive."

He moved to Tulsa in 2020 to work for the George Kaiser Family Foundation, a major investor in much of Tulsa's tech scene. He then went on to launch Tulsa Innovation Labs to increase opportunities for entrepreneurs in the city. Though he has since left Tulsa Innovation Labs, he said diversity, equity and inclusion were always part of its founding mission. There is underlying tension simmering between Tulsa's tech hub and the governor's office, he said, and the executive order could possibly harm Oklahoma's economic prospects.

"Especially for a state that already struggles with perception issues around inclusion," he said, "the order does nothing to create jobs for Oklahomans, and worse, it sends the wrong message to outside tech talent and investors. Diversity is a core attribute of a thriving innovation economy."

But what about the Black Wall Street neighborhood? Would a DEI backlash affect the efforts to rebuild? Kelsey Davis, a founder of the hiring platform Cllctve, said Black Wall Street will continue to rebuild itself and leverage the knowledge and wisdom that has sustained it this long despite the century of racist attacks it has faced. Davis moved to Tulsa two years ago and bought a house on Black Wall Street, looking to build value and equity in the local community.

The area has seen changes, she said, and the anti-DEI backlash can only hurt if it makes people divest from fighting for equity in their own communities. "It's necessary that we examine ourselves to ask what we are individually doing to help restore and maintain the freedom and access toward wealth creation that our ancestors had 103 years ago before the massacre," she said. "We must also continue to consider what economic liberties were sacrificed for social progress and reevaluate how to achieve both in this modern era."

For the most part, though, and for many, it's just business as usual. "Local leaders can't get distracted or discouraged by naysayers," Lalla said. "Tulsa just needs to keep doing what it's doing."

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Dominic-Madori Davis is a senior venture capital and startup reporter at TechCrunch. She is based in New York...

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Orlando has all the ingredients to be the next big startup hub

There's much potential for Orlando to be what Austin is to Texas, what [Atlanta is to Georgia](#) — a booming hub where startups flock from around the world to dream, innovate and grow.

The numbers are already showing potential: New PitchBook data found that in the first half of this year, a little more than \$360 million was invested in the Orlando-Kissimmee metro area, way more than the \$144 million invested in H1 last year. Q2 2022 saw \$320 million invested, tracking higher than the \$90 million and \$30 million allocated in Q2 2021 and 2020, respectively.

Not totally surprisingly, Q3 saw a dip from the \$160 million invested last year to just near \$23 million this year. But compare that to the numbers PitchBook has for Gainesville: Gator City has received just \$9.57 million in capital investment this year. Or even Port Saint Lucie, where around \$12 million in capital was allocated this year.

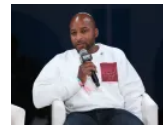
“When people hear Orlando, they don’t think tech,” [Jordan Walker](#), the Orlando-based co-founder of the messaging platform Yac, told TechCrunch. “People automatically think Disney World theme parks, but there is a lot of innovation out here.”

“The Orlando tech community is a very inclusive and very collaborative community,” [David Adelson](#), the chief innovation officer at the [Orlando Economic Partnership](#), added. “We have tremendous amounts of velocity happening and we’ve been quiet in how

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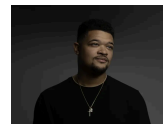


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Payment platform Lava raises \$5.8M to build digital wallets for the ‘agent-native economy’

Dominic-Madori Davis

- 19 hours ago

we’ve told the story, but there is a huge underswell of stealth technology being built here.”

TechCrunch conducted [a vibe check](#) to see what’s happening right now in Orlando’s burgeoning venture scene, as well as what needs to occur for it to continue thriving. Founders and investors mentioned efforts tapping into the entrepreneurial community, while Adelson highlighted the city’s plans to become the center of the metaverse. All of this could lead to the one thing Orlando really needs in order to make a bigger splash: a beacon.

“Every major city has a beacon,” Walker’s co-founder, [Hunter McKinley](#), told TechCrunch. He pointed out that Miami Mayor Francis Suarez and Austin’s Capital Factory have been leaders in driving innovation to their cities.



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“Look at niches that seem to stand out in the city and find the most influential people to incentivize them to become a beacon,” he continued. “Orlando

needs a Suarez or Capital Factory to take ownership.”

Orlando: The Silicon Swamp?

Orlando would do well as a venture hub. It has an emerging art scene, an incubator of talent from the University of Central Florida, which is one of the largest schools in the United States, and good weather with a low cost of living compared to Los Angeles, San Francisco and even Miami.

There are already a few well-regarded VC firms in the area, such as [DeepWork Capital](#) and [Florida Funders](#). The city also has a rising entrepreneurial scene and is home to events like Orlando Innovation Week, put on by the nonprofit Synapse Florida.

Christine Caven, director of communications at [PS27 Ventures](#) and the vice president of [statGNV](#), said it’s only a matter of time before more investors start paying attention to Orlando, especially as the venture community continues to migrate to the Sunshine State. This, paired with the continued support of companies already in the area, could prove to have a big payoff, she said.

“Companies like Yac are bringing in investors from outside of Florida,” Caven told TechCrunch, noting that Yac’s popularity piqued the interest of VCs, encouraging them to see what else is being built in the area. “Orlando still has some areas to improve and grow, but I think it’s just getting started.”

A boost is also set to be provided by the Orlando Economic Partnership’s efforts to market the city as [the new center](#) of the metaverse, or, as it will simply be known, the MetaCenter. Adelson said the city’s dip into web3 makes perfect sense because it wraps all of the city’s most prominent industries into one idea: There’s gaming (EA Sports is [building a headquarters](#) in Orlando), education (UCF and Full

Sail University), entertainment (Disney and Universal), and even [augmented reality](#) (from the city's previous work with aerospace company Lockheed Martin).

"I look at Miami and I think about blockchain. I think about crypto, but that's a little volatile for us," Adelson said. "As everyone is looking at this gold rush right now, we're more about providing the shovels and giving people the tools to create for this next generation."

However, there are a few hurdles for the city to overcome. Ken Hall, the vice president of DeepWork Capital, noted the brain drain that often occurs after students graduate from the university system. He said people feel they must leave the area to build a great company or join a good startup, a trend he hopes is reversed by the recent successes in the city.

[Kirubha Perumalsamy](#), a founder from the area, agreed with that sentiment, saying that more talent staying in the area provides opportunities for aspiring founders to learn, network and connect. Another issue is that companies in the city need to find more and bigger exits, he said. There have been two exits this year in the Orlando-Kissimmee area, down from six last year, according to PitchBook data.

"As more and more people successfully exit their company or make a few investments that worked out, they can share their learnings with people," Perumalsamy said. "There isn't a lack of ambition, just a lack of guidance."

Walker hopes that the new focus on underserved markets proves fruitful for Orlando and his company. PitchBook found that the entire Southeast region saw \$1.27 billion invested this year, which is already more than the \$1 billion invested by this time

last year. This gives Walker hope, as his company just released a new feature, and he’s hoping to market it as a “shining” product to emerge from a tertiary tech city.

“The infrastructure is there,” Walker said. “The city just needs to attract talent, work with people already here, put them in front of the right resources, partnerships, customers, VCs. It’s really just exposing what’s happening in Orlando aside from Disney World.”

Or, as Hall puts it, the world of venture is a long game. “And Silicon Valley wasn’t built overnight.”

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Dominic-Madori Davis

Senior Reporter, Venture |

Dominic-Madori Davis is a senior venture capital and startup reporter at TechCrunch. She is based in New York...

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